

FROM PROCLAMATION TO CREED

A Detailed History of the Early Church's Confessions of Faith

From 1 Corinthians 15 to Nicaea, Constantinople, Chalcedon,
the Apostles' Creed, and the Athanasian Creed

Historical narrative, full creed texts, scholarly debates, primary-source quotations, notes, and bibliography

Editorial Note

This study uses the word *creed* broadly at first, because the earliest Christian materials are not always fixed, council-approved texts. Some are hymns, confessions, preaching summaries, baptismal questions, or "rules of faith." The book then narrows toward creeds in the stricter sense: stable verbal formulas carrying ecclesial authority. J. N. D. Kelly famously defined a creed as "a fixed formula summarising the essential articles" of a religion and possessing church sanction.⁸

Biblical passages are quoted from the public-domain World English Bible, with occasional punctuation adjusted for readability. Ancient creeds and patristic passages are presented in lightly modernized English based primarily on the public-domain translations collected by Philip Schaff, the *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, and the *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*. Where a translation choice is historically disputed, the discussion identifies it.

Dates are approximate where the evidence is approximate. In particular, the date of the tradition behind 1 Corinthians 15 cannot be established to a single year. The distinction between the date of Paul's letter, the date when Paul received a tradition, and the date when that tradition first took verbal form is maintained throughout.

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A Timeline at a Glance

- c. 30** Death of Jesus; resurrection proclamation begins among his followers.
- c. 32-36** Paul's conversion, depending on the chronology adopted.
- c. 35-39** Paul's first Jerusalem visit, where he meets Cephas and James (Galatians 1:18-19).
- c. 53-55** Paul writes 1 Corinthians and quotes the tradition in 15:3-7.
- c. 90-120** Didache in its final form; trine baptismal language is attested.
- c. 150** Justin Martyr describes baptism into the name of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.
- c. 180** Irenaeus articulates the "rule of truth" against Gnostic teachers.
- c. 200** Tertullian gives several versions of the rule of faith.
- 3rd-4th c.** Interrogatory baptismal creeds develop into declarative symbols.
- 325** Council of Nicaea confesses the Son as true God and homoousios with the Father.
- 381** Council of Constantinople confirms Nicene faith; the creed associated with the council expands confession of the Holy Spirit.
- 431** Council of Ephesus forbids a rival faith and condemns Nestorius.
- 451** Council of Chalcedon issues its Definition: one and the same Christ in two natures.
- late 5th-early 6th c.** The Athanasian Creed emerges in the Latin West.
- 6th-11th c.** The Western addition of filioque spreads and becomes a major East-West dispute.
- 680-681** Constantinople III teaches two natural wills and operations in Christ.
- 787** Nicaea II defends the veneration of icons while distinguishing veneration from worship.

1. Before the Council Chamber: What a Creed Is

The history of Christian creeds does not begin with an emperor, a marble hall, or hundreds of bishops arguing over a Greek vowel. It begins with memory and proclamation. Before Christians possessed a bound New Testament, they preached, baptized, prayed, sang, and handed on compact summaries of what they believed God had done in Jesus Christ.

The English word *creed* comes from the Latin *credo*, "I believe." The Greek word most often used for an authoritative creed was *symbolon*. In ordinary Greek, a symbolon could be a token broken into matching halves: two parties proved their identity by fitting the pieces together. Applied to Christian confession, the image is suggestive. A creed served as a token of recognition - a verbal pattern by which a community identified the faith into which it baptized and the communion to which it belonged.⁸

Yet not every concise theological statement is a creed in the same sense. Historians usually distinguish several overlapping forms:

- **Kerygma** - the apostolic proclamation of God's saving act in Christ, especially death, resurrection, exaltation, and coming judgment.
- **Confession** - a short declaration such as "Jesus is Lord" or "Jesus is the Christ."
- **Hymn or poetic formula** - rhythmic material embedded in a letter, such as Philippians 2:6-11.
- **Rule of faith** - a flexible narrative summary of the apostolic message used to interpret Scripture and expose rival teachings.
- **Baptismal symbol** - a memorized, often three-part confession associated with renunciation, instruction, and immersion.
- **Conciliar creed or definition** - an authoritative text adopted by bishops to mark the boundaries of public teaching.

This progression was not a replacement of spontaneous faith by sterile bureaucracy. It was an attempt to answer a recurring problem: the same biblical words could be used with radically different meanings. Arius could call Christ "Son of God." So could Alexander of Alexandria. Nestorius could honor Christ; Cyril of Alexandria could do the same. The disagreement lay in what these words permitted and excluded. Creeds became grammatical fences around the church's reading of Scripture.

A creed is not the whole Christian faith. It is a map of the points at which the church judged that the road could no longer safely remain unmarked.

Creeds also had several practical lives at once. They were baptismal vows spoken at the edge of the font; catechetical outlines memorized by converts; liturgical texts recited in worship; tests of episcopal communion; and, in moments of controversy, instruments of exclusion. Their history therefore includes prayer and politics, pastoral care and imperial pressure, profound theological insight and painful division.

2. The First Great Witness: 1 Corinthians 15:3-8

Around the middle of the first century, Paul wrote to a divided congregation in Corinth. Some members questioned whether the dead would be raised. Paul did not begin his answer with speculation. He reminded them of the gospel they had already received and on which their identity rested. Then he introduced a sequence with the language of transmission: "I delivered to you first of all that which I also received."

1 Corinthians 15:3-8 - The Received and Delivered Tradition

For I delivered to you first of all that which I also received: that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, that he was buried,

that he was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures,
and that he appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve.
Then he appeared to over five hundred brothers at once, most of whom remain until now, but some have also fallen asleep.
Then he appeared to James, then to all the apostles,
and last of all, as to the child born at the wrong time, he appeared to me also.

World English Bible; paragraphing added to display the formulaic sequence. Most scholars identify at least verses 3b-5 as inherited material, while debating how far the received formula extends.

The repeated "that" clauses give the passage a memorized cadence: Christ died; he was buried; he was raised; he appeared. Death and resurrection are each interpreted. His death was "for our sins" and "according to the Scriptures"; his raising occurred "on the third day" and likewise "according to the Scriptures." Burial anchors death in the fate of a body. Appearance anchors resurrection in encounters claimed by named persons and groups.

Several features lead many scholars to conclude that Paul is not composing freely at this point:

- He explicitly uses the paired verbs **received** and **delivered**, language Paul also uses for tradition in 1 Corinthians 11:23.
- The passage has a balanced, mnemonic structure unlike the argumentative prose that follows.
- Some vocabulary or expressions are unusual in Paul, including "the Twelve" and the clustered phrase "according to the Scriptures."
- The sequence names Cephas and James, figures associated with the Jerusalem church whom Paul personally met.
- Paul adds himself afterward in a strikingly personal and unbalanced clause, suggesting a transition from inherited list to autobiographical argument.²

There is nevertheless no surviving manuscript in which the "creed" appears separately. It is a reconstructed tradition embedded in Paul's letter. Scholars infer its existence from literary features, vocabulary, and Paul's own claim to transmit what he received. The word *creed* is therefore useful but slightly anachronistic: this was probably an oral proclamation or confessional summary before it was a churchwide fixed text.

The likely boundaries of the formula

The narrowest common reconstruction ends with the appearance to Cephas in verse 5. This yields a tight parallel: death / burial and resurrection / appearance. Others include "then to the Twelve," or extend the received list through James and all the apostles in verse 7. Verse 6b - "most of whom remain until now" - sounds like Paul's present-day comment. Verse 8 is unmistakably Pauline autobiography. Dale Allison, among others, judges verses 6b and 8 to be Paul's additions, while allowing that other parts may also have been adjusted.⁶

Even the phrase "on the third day" is discussed. Some interpret it primarily as scriptural - often connecting it with Hosea 6:2, Jonah traditions, or a broad biblical pattern of divine action on the third day. Others see it as both chronological and scriptural. The creed does not narrate an empty tomb, but "died ... buried ... raised" can be read as a compact sequence involving the body that was buried. Whether this independently proves an empty tomb is disputed; it certainly shows that resurrection was not presented merely as the survival of Jesus' influence.

What did "appeared" mean?

The Greek verb *ophthe* can be translated "he appeared" or "he was seen." In biblical Greek it can describe revelatory manifestations of God or angels, and it can also introduce ordinary visual encounter. Paul uses the same verb for Cephas, the Twelve, the five hundred, James, the apostles, and himself. That creates continuity among the claims, but it does not tell us that every experience was identical in mode. Paul's own encounter, described elsewhere as a revelation and a heavenly vision, may have differed from the experiences of those who knew Jesus before his death.

Historical interpretation divides here. Some scholars understand the list as testimony to bodily encounters with the risen Jesus. Others explain the appearances as visionary experiences, grief-related experiences, ecstatic revelations, or a spectrum of experiences later narrated in more concrete forms. The passage establishes that resurrection appearances were claimed very early; the historical cause and phenomenology of those experiences remain debated.

3. How Early Is the Corinthian Tradition?

The date of Paul's letter is the secure outer boundary. Most chronologies place 1 Corinthians around AD 53-55, during Paul's ministry in Ephesus. That means the tradition existed before the mid-50s. The more difficult question is how much earlier.

Paul gives two chronological clues. First, he says he received the tradition. Second, Galatians 1:18-19 reports that three years after his call he visited Jerusalem for fifteen days with Cephas and also saw James. Depending on the date assigned to Jesus' death and Paul's conversion, this visit is often placed in the middle or later 30s. Because Cephas and James appear in the Corinthian list, many scholars consider this Jerusalem visit a plausible occasion for Paul to have received or confirmed the formula. Plausible, however, is not the same as demonstrable.

"This tradition ... was formulated as tradition within months of Jesus' death."

James D. G. Dunn, Jesus Remembered, pp. 854-55.³

James D. G. Dunn represents a very early estimate. Gerd Luedemann, who did not accept the resurrection as a historical miracle, likewise argued that elements of the tradition belong within the first two years after the crucifixion and not later than three.⁴ These judgments are often cited because they show that an early date is not limited to conservative Christian scholarship.

But the phrase "most scholars date it within two or three years" can become more confident than the evidence permits. Bart Ehrman has cautioned that *pre-Pauline* means, at minimum, that the material existed before Paul quoted it in the letter. It does not by itself prove that the formula was already fixed before Paul's conversion.⁵ The date depends on an additional inference: that Paul received it early, probably from Jerusalem leaders, rather than at some later point in his ministry.

A responsible range of views

1. **Very early formulation - months to roughly three years.** This view emphasizes Jerusalem provenance, the named figures Cephas and James, Paul's early contact with them, and the compact Semitic or mnemonic character of the wording.
2. **Early but not precisely datable - sometime in the 30s or 40s.** This view affirms inherited tradition while resisting a specific year. It distinguishes the origin of individual claims from the date when they were gathered into the present sequence.
3. **Pre-letter but possibly shaped by Paul.** This view sees a traditional core but gives Paul a larger editorial role: arranging appearances, adding clauses, or refining the theological language.
4. **More radical skepticism.** A minority questions the extent of pre-Pauline material or argues that "received" need not imply a verbatim formula. Even here, the passage still witnesses to resurrection belief by the mid-first century and to Paul's appeal to earlier authorities.

The strongest historical conclusion is therefore layered: belief that Jesus died, was buried, was raised, and appeared to followers was not a late second-century legend. It belonged to the first generation and was already treated as the common gospel before Paul wrote 1 Corinthians. The narrower claim that every line of verses 3-7 was memorized in Jerusalem within months of the crucifixion is possible, and defended by major scholars, but not provable with equal confidence.

Why the passage matters

The significance of 1 Corinthians 15 is not merely that it is early. It reveals the shape of earliest Christian identity. The center is not a timeless moral program but an announced event interpreted through Israel's Scriptures: Messiah died for sins, was buried, was raised, and appeared. The formula binds theology to history and history to Scripture. It also places communal testimony before later narrative elaboration. The Gospels tell resurrection stories; 1 Corinthians gives an earlier list-like proclamation.

The passage also shows that creed and controversy were connected from the beginning. Paul recites the inherited gospel because some Corinthians deny the future resurrection. Tradition is not used to end thought but to set its starting point: "If Christ has not been raised," Paul insists, Christian preaching and faith collapse. The earliest creed is therefore an argument about reality, not merely a badge of group identity.

4. Other New Testament Confessions and Hymns

The New Testament contains many shorter formulas that helped Christians name their faith before later creeds existed. Scholars debate which are pre-Pauline or pre-literary, but their compactness and rhythmic shape reveal a culture of repeated confession.

The Shema Reframed around Father and Lord - 1 Corinthians 8:6

Yet to us there is one God, the Father, of whom are all things, and we for him;
and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things, and we live through him.

World English Bible. Many scholars see Paul rereading Israel's confession of one God in a way that includes Jesus within the divine identity while preserving monotheistic language. ⁷

This sentence echoes the Jewish Shema, "YHWH our God, YHWH is one" (Deuteronomy 6:4), while distributing the terms "God" and "Lord" between the Father and Jesus Christ. It is not a fourth-century formula of one essence and three persons, but it is crucial background for the later Nicene question: how could Christians worship Jesus without abandoning the one God of Israel?

The Christ Hymn - Philippians 2:6-11

Christ Jesus, who, existing in the form of God, did not consider equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, taking the form of a servant, being made in the likeness of men.
And being found in human form, he humbled himself, becoming obedient to death, yes, the death of the cross.
Therefore God also highly exalted him, and gave to him the name which is above every name, that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those in heaven, those on earth, and those under the earth, and that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

World English Bible, lightly arranged. Whether Paul composed or quoted the hymn is debated; its movement from humiliation to exaltation became foundational for Christian reflection on incarnation.

The climax alludes to Isaiah 45:23, where every knee bows to YHWH. The hymn joins the crucified Jesus to that scriptural scene while concluding "to the glory of God the Father." Later creeds would seek conceptual language for the relation already enacted in Christian worship.

A Confession of Incarnation and Vindication - 1 Timothy 3:16

He was revealed in the flesh,
justified in the spirit,
seen by angels,
preached among the nations,
believed on in the world,
and received up in glory.

World English Bible, using the reading "He who" / "He" rather than the later manuscript reading "God." The six-line rhythm is commonly treated as hymnic or confessional material.

Jesus as Davidic and Vindicated Son - Romans 1:3-4

Concerning his Son, who was born of the offspring of David according to the flesh, who was declared to be the Son of God with power according to the Spirit of holiness, by the resurrection from the dead: Jesus Christ our Lord.

World English Bible. Many scholars detect traditional material, though they disagree over whether it implies adoption at resurrection or a public designation of a preexistent Son.

These texts warn against imagining a simple line from "low" first-century belief to "high" fourth-century dogma. The New Testament contains multiple patterns: exaltation, incarnation, agency, Wisdom, Sonship, Lordship, and worship. Nicaea did not invent the question of Jesus' relation to God. It inherited a dense scriptural and liturgical field in which Christians already prayed through Christ, baptized in a triune name, invoked Jesus as Lord, and still confessed one God.

5. The Rule of Faith in the Second Century

By the second century, Christianity had spread across languages and regions. It also faced teachers who interpreted its Scriptures through radically different cosmologies. Some groups distinguished the creator from a higher unknown God. Some treated the material world as a prison. Some denied that Christ truly took flesh or suffered. Others separated the heavenly Christ from the human Jesus. The church's answer was not initially a single universal creed but a recurring narrative summary called the *rule of faith* or *rule of truth*.

The rule was flexible in wording but stable in plot: one Creator; the prophets; Jesus Christ, truly incarnate; his passion under Pontius Pilate; resurrection and ascension; the Holy Spirit; the church; the resurrection of the flesh; and judgment. It functioned as a guide to reading Scripture as one coherent drama rather than a collection of coded fragments.

Irenaeus of Lyons - The Rule of Truth (c. 180)

The Church, though dispersed throughout the whole world, even to the ends of the earth, has received from the apostles and their disciples this faith:

in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of heaven and earth and the seas and all things that are in them;

and in one Christ Jesus, the Son of God, who became incarnate for our salvation;

and in the Holy Spirit, who proclaimed through the prophets the dispensations of God, the advents, the birth from a virgin, the passion, the resurrection from the dead, and the bodily ascension into heaven of the beloved Christ Jesus our Lord, and his manifestation from heaven in the glory of the Father to gather all things in one, and to raise up anew all flesh of the whole human race.

Adapted from Irenaeus, Against Heresies 1.10.1, Roberts-Donaldson translation. Irenaeus continues with judgment and the differing destinies of the righteous and the wicked. ⁹

Irenaeus does not claim that every church repeats precisely these words. His point is that churches separated by geography confess one apostolic story. The unity is narrative and ecclesial before it is verbally standardized. Against Gnostic myths of many divine beings and layered heavens, Irenaeus insists that the God who created matter is the God who saves it, and that salvation culminates in the resurrection of flesh.

Tertullian - A Rule of Faith (early 3rd century)

There is one only God, and he is none other than the Creator of the world, who produced all things out of nothing through his own Word, first of all sent forth;

that this Word is called his Son, and, under the name of God, was seen in various ways by the patriarchs, was always heard in the prophets, and at last was brought down by the Spirit and power of the Father into the Virgin Mary, was made flesh in her womb, and, being born of her, went forth as Jesus Christ;

that he preached the new law and the new promise of the kingdom of heaven, worked miracles, was crucified, rose again the third day, was caught up into the heavens, and sat at the right hand of the Father;

that he sent instead of himself the power of the Holy Spirit to lead those who believe;

and that he will come with glory to take the saints to the enjoyment of everlasting life and the heavenly promises, and to condemn the wicked to everlasting fire, after the resurrection of both good and evil together with the restoration of their flesh.

Adapted from Tertullian, Prescription Against Heretics 13. His other rule-of-faith statements vary in wording while preserving the same structure. ¹⁰

Tertullian's formulation already sounds close to later Western creeds, but it remains an exposition rather than a universally fixed liturgical text. Its polemical emphasis is revealing: creation out of nothing, continuity between

prophets and Christ, genuine birth from Mary, actual crucifixion, bodily resurrection, and future judgment. The rule defended the goodness and continuity of God's work from creation to consummation.

Scripture, tradition, and the rule

Modern debates often force an opposition between Scripture and tradition that does not map neatly onto the second century. Irenaeus appealed to the public apostolic Scriptures and to the public teaching preserved in apostolic churches. The rule of faith was not an independent secret revelation. It was the church's summary of Scripture's plot, used against interpreters who also quoted biblical texts but rearranged their meaning.

This is the direct ancestor of the creed's boundary-making role. Heresy, in this setting, often meant not disbelief in Christian vocabulary but a rival grammar for it. "Father," "Son," "salvation," and "resurrection" could all be redefined. The rule said: these terms belong to this story - one Creator, one incarnation, one economy of salvation, one resurrection of the flesh.

6. Baptism, Catechesis, and the Old Roman Symbol

The rule of faith was prose; baptism gave it a ritual skeleton. Matthew 28:19 commands baptism "in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit." Early Christian descriptions show candidates renouncing rival loyalties, receiving instruction, and answering questions of faith before immersion. The threefold pattern of Father, Son, and Spirit became a natural frame for fuller confession.

Justin Martyr, writing in Rome around the middle of the second century, says converts are washed "in the name of God, the Father and Lord of the universe, and of our Savior Jesus Christ, and of the Holy Spirit."¹¹ The *Apostolic Tradition*, a church-order text whose attribution to Hippolytus and precise date are disputed, preserves an interrogatory form closely related to the Old Roman Creed. Modern scholarship increasingly treats the document as composite, but the baptismal questions remain important evidence for the development of confession.¹²

An Interrogatory Baptismal Confession

Do you believe in God the Father Almighty?

I believe.

Do you believe in Christ Jesus, the Son of God, who was born through the Holy Spirit from the Virgin Mary, was crucified under Pontius Pilate, died, was buried, rose on the third day alive from the dead, ascended into heaven, sat at the right hand of the Father, and will come to judge the living and the dead?

I believe.

Do you believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy Church, and the resurrection of the flesh?

I believe.

*Adapted from Apostolic Tradition 21. The text survives through later translations and recensions; wording and dating should not be treated as a pristine transcript from Rome around AD 215.*¹²

The repeated "Do you believe? - I believe" shows the creed in action. Belief is not only information about God. It is a public allegiance enacted bodily. The candidate descends into water, answers, and is baptized. Later declarative creeds preserve the first-person singular because they grow from this personal act: "I believe."

The Old Roman Symbol

The earliest complete surviving form of the Old Roman Symbol appears in Greek in a letter of Marcellus of Ancyra to Julius of Rome around AD 340-341. Rufinus of Aquileia gives a Latin form around AD 400. Scholars debate how far the text can be projected backward, but it clearly represents an older Roman baptismal tradition and stands behind the Apostles' Creed. Kelly prints the Greek and Latin witnesses side by side.¹³

The Old Roman Symbol

I believe in God the Father Almighty;

and in Christ Jesus, his only Son, our Lord,
 who was born of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary,
 who under Pontius Pilate was crucified and buried,
 on the third day rose again from the dead,
 ascended into heaven,
 sits at the right hand of the Father,
 from where he will come to judge the living and the dead;
 and in the Holy Spirit,
 the holy Church,
 the forgiveness of sins,
 the resurrection of the flesh,
 [and life everlasting].

Based on the Greek witness of Marcellus and the Latin witness of Rufinus. The bracketed final clause appears in the Greek witness but not Rufinus's Roman form. ¹³

Compared with the later Apostles' Creed, the Old Roman Symbol lacks several familiar phrases: creator of heaven and earth; conceived; suffered; descended to the dead; catholic; communion of saints; and life everlasting in some witnesses. The development was gradual and regional. The Apostles' Creed was not dictated in final form by the twelve apostles, one line each, despite a beautiful legend repeated in the fourth and fifth centuries.

The creed called "apostolic" is apostolic primarily in content and claimed continuity, not because historians possess evidence that the Twelve jointly composed its final wording.

7. The Apostles' Creed

The Apostles' Creed is the mature Western descendant of the Old Roman Symbol. Its present form emerges through additions in Gaul, Spain, and neighboring regions and is fully attested in the early medieval period. It was later received at Rome and became the standard baptismal and catechetical creed of Western Christianity. ¹⁴

Rufinus, writing around AD 404, relays the tradition that the apostles, before dispersing, each contributed an article. The story gave imaginative form to the creed's claim to summarize apostolic teaching. Historical criticism does not accept the legend as an account of composition. The creed developed over centuries, and some clauses can be tracked in regional texts before they appear in the received form.

The Apostles' Creed - Common Western Form

I believe in God, the Father Almighty, creator of heaven and earth.
 I believe in Jesus Christ, his only Son, our Lord.
 He was conceived by the Holy Spirit and born of the Virgin Mary.
 He suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died, and was buried.
 He descended to the dead.
 On the third day he rose again.
 He ascended into heaven and is seated at the right hand of God the Father Almighty.
 From there he will come to judge the living and the dead.
 I believe in the Holy Spirit,
 the holy catholic Church,
 the communion of saints,
 the forgiveness of sins,

the resurrection of the body,
and the life everlasting. Amen.

Modern English rendering of the received Latin text. "Catholic" here means universal or according to the whole, not exclusively the later Roman Catholic communion.

How the clauses developed

"Creator of heaven and earth." This makes explicit what the older title "Father Almighty" implied and strengthens the anti-Gnostic confession that the Father of Jesus Christ is the maker of the material world.

"Conceived by the Holy Spirit." The Old Roman form said Christ was born of the Holy Spirit and Mary. The later wording distinguishes conception and birth while preserving divine initiative and genuine human birth.

"Suffered." This word underlines the reality of the passion against docetic interpretations in which Christ only seemed to suffer.

"He descended to the dead." The Latin *descendit ad inferos* can mean descent to the lower regions or to the realm of the dead. It is not identical to the English image of hell as the place of final punishment. The clause entered Western creeds gradually and was interpreted in several ways: as a restatement of burial, as Christ's solidarity with the dead, or as a victorious proclamation to imprisoned spirits.

"Catholic" and "communion of saints." Catholic means the whole or universal church. *Communio sanctorum* can grammatically mean communion of holy persons or sharing in holy things, including sacraments. The two senses enriched one another in later interpretation.

"Resurrection of the body." The older "resurrection of the flesh" was often retained. Both oppose the idea that salvation means permanent escape from embodiment.

Why it endured

The Apostles' Creed is short, narrative, and personal. It moves from creation to incarnation, passion, resurrection, ascension, judgment, Spirit, church, forgiveness, bodily resurrection, and eternal life. Unlike Nicaea, it contains no technical term such as *homoousios*. Its strength is not conciliar precision but catechetical proportion. It tells the story a Christian enters.

Its limits are equally important. It does not explicitly say that the Son is true God from true God, nor does it elaborate the deity of the Holy Spirit. Arian or subordinationist readings could affirm many of its clauses. For that reason the Apostles' Creed and Nicene Creed became complementary in the West: one a baptismal narrative, the other a doctrinal guardrail forged in controversy.

8. The Road to Nicaea

The Council of Nicaea did not meet because the church had never thought about Christ before AD 325. It met because several inherited ways of speaking no longer fit together peacefully. Christians confessed one God, called Jesus divine, worshiped him, described him as God's Word and Wisdom, and distinguished him from the Father. The question was how to state all of this without falling into either two gods or a Son who was less than truly divine.

Origen and the unresolved inheritance

Origen of Alexandria, writing in the early third century, taught the eternal generation of the Son and denied that there was ever a time when God lacked his Word. Yet he also used hierarchical language and spoke of the Father as the ultimate source. Later theologians could appeal to different sides of this inheritance. The fourth-century crisis was therefore not simply Bible-believers against philosophers. It was an intra-Christian struggle over how to coordinate Scripture, worship, and inherited theological models.

Arius and Alexander

Around AD 318, a dispute broke out in Alexandria between the presbyter Arius and Bishop Alexander. Arius feared that if the Son were without origin in the same way as the Father, Christian teaching would collapse the distinction between Father and Son or divide the one God. He therefore emphasized the Father's unique unbegotten status. The Son existed before the ages and was the agent of creation, but he had his existence from the Father's will. Opponents summarized Arian logic in slogans: "There was when he was not" and the Son was "from things that were not."

Arius did not present Jesus as an ordinary creature. The Son was uniquely exalted, preexistent, and the creator of everything else. But if the Son was made, changeable by nature, and external to the Father's own being, could he truly reveal God and unite creatures to God? Alexander and the young deacon Athanasius argued that salvation required more than a supreme intermediary. Only the one who truly shares the divine life can give divine life.

Constantine and the imperial setting

Emperor Constantine had recently consolidated control of the Roman Empire. Christian division threatened the unity he valued, and he summoned bishops to Nicaea in Bithynia. Estimates of attendance vary; ancient traditions later celebrated 318 bishops, while modern historians commonly infer something above 250. Most came from the eastern empire, though representatives from the West attended. Constantine opened the council and used imperial influence to secure agreement, but he did not write the creed or settle its theology by himself.¹⁵

The council addressed more than Arius: the date of Easter, the Meletian schism in Egypt, and disciplinary canons also occupied the bishops. Yet the creed became its lasting theological act. The crucial move was to supplement scriptural phrases with terms designed to exclude Arian interpretations.

9. The Creed of Nicaea (325)

The Creed of Nicaea with Its Anathemas

We believe in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of all things visible and invisible.

And in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, begotten from the Father, only-begotten, that is, from the essence of the Father;

God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God;

begotten, not made;

of one essence with the Father;

through whom all things came to be, things in heaven and things on earth;

who for us humans and for our salvation came down and was incarnate, became human,

suffered, and rose on the third day,

ascended into heaven,

and is coming to judge the living and the dead.

And in the Holy Spirit.

But those who say, "There was when he was not," and "Before he was begotten he was not," and that he came to be from things that were not, or who assert that the Son of God is of a different hypostasis or essence, or is created, or changeable, or alterable - these the catholic and apostolic Church anathematizes.

*English rendering based on the Greek text preserved by Athanasius, Eusebius, and later conciliar collections.*¹⁶

The creed's architecture

The opening retains the one-God confession and names the Father as maker. The second article is expansive because the controversy centered on the Son. The final mention of the Spirit is brief; the full fourth-century dispute over the Spirit had not yet matured. The anathemas reveal exactly which readings the positive clauses were meant to exclude.

"Begotten, not made"

Arians could speak of the Son as begotten if begetting meant that God caused him to exist before all other creatures. Nicaea drew a categorical line: generation is not creation. The Son is from the Father, but not as the world is from God. The relation is internal to divine life rather than an act by which something external begins to exist.

"From the essence of the Father"

This phrase directly rejected the claim that the Son came "from nothing." It did not mean a physical division of divine material. Ancient opponents worried about exactly that implication, which is one reason the language required explanation. The council meant that the Son's origin is not in the created order but in the Father's own divine reality.

Homoousios - "of one essence"

The most famous term is Greek *homoousios*. It can be translated "of the same essence," "consubstantial," or "of one being." The word was not a biblical quotation and carried an ambiguous earlier history. In some contexts it could suggest numerical identity; in others, membership in the same kind. Nicaea used it as a boundary term: whatever else must be said about the distinction of Father and Son, the Son is not on the creaturely side of the Creator-creature divide.

The term did not instantly settle the controversy. Bishops could sign it while interpreting it differently. Some feared it encouraged Sabellianism, in which Father and Son are merely modes of one person. Others disliked the council's use of *hypostasis* and *ousia* as apparent synonyms in the anathema, because later theology would distinguish them: one *ousia*, three *hypostases*. Nicaea gave the church a decisive word before the church possessed a universally accepted conceptual grammar for that word.

Eusebius of Caesarea explains his signature

Eusebius of Caesarea wrote to his church explaining why he accepted the council. He reported that "of one essence" was interpreted to mean that the Son is truly from the Father, yet without being a part or bodily division of the Father.¹⁷ His letter is valuable because it shows negotiation, clarification, and the effort to distinguish Nicene language from materialistic misunderstandings.

Nicaea succeeded not by explaining every mystery, but by ruling out one answer: the Son through whom all things were made cannot himself belong among the things made.

Anathema and authority

The creed ends not merely with affirmation but condemnation. An anathema marked teachings incompatible with ecclesial communion. Modern readers may find the language severe, and the history of coercion attached to doctrinal politics warrants moral scrutiny. Yet in its original setting the anathema also made the creed intelligible. Without the excluded propositions, "true God" and "begotten" could be absorbed into an Arian vocabulary. The boundary clarified the confession.

10. The Long Crisis after Nicaea

The familiar story - Arius lost, orthodoxy won, and the church moved on - is false. Nicaea began a struggle that lasted more than half a century. Constantine soon permitted Arius to return from exile. Athanasius was repeatedly deposed and exiled. Councils produced alternative formulas. Emperors favored different parties. The label "Arian" covered a wide range of positions, many of which rejected Arius' sharper slogans while also rejecting *homoousios*. R. P. C. Hanson and Lewis Ayres have emphasized the diversity of this post-Nicene landscape.¹⁸

Why the Nicene term was resisted

Some bishops objected because *homoousios* was unscriptural. Others associated it with Paul of Samosata, a third-century bishop accused of a form of dynamic monarchianism. Still others thought it erased the personal distinction between Father and Son. Many were not secret Arians; they sought a formula that affirmed the Son's unique divine status while protecting the monarchy of the Father and the reality of three.

A series of councils at Antioch, Sirmium, Rimini, Seleucia, and elsewhere generated creeds using terms such as "like according to the Scriptures" or "like in essence." The dispute was not about one letter in isolation - *homoousios* versus *homoiousios* - though that later shorthand is memorable. It concerned the source, status, and eternal relation of the Son, and the language capable of expressing it.

The Cappadocian clarification

Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nazianzus, and Gregory of Nyssa helped stabilize a grammar of one *ousia* and three *hypostases*: one divine being or essence, three irreducible persons or concrete realities. They did not solve the Trinity as a logical puzzle. They clarified that unity of essence does not erase personal distinction, and that personal distinction does not divide the one divine nature.

The Holy Spirit now became central. Groups later called Pneumatomachians or "fighters against the Spirit" accepted much Nicene teaching about the Son but denied that the Spirit should be confessed as fully divine. Basil argued from the Spirit's role in sanctification, baptism, worship, and the scriptural coordination of Father, Son, and Spirit. Gregory of Nazianzus spoke more directly of the Spirit as God. The council of 381 would confirm this trajectory without using *homoousios* of the Spirit in its creed.

Theodosius and the political victory of Nicene Christianity

Emperor Theodosius I supported the Nicene cause and convened the Council of Constantinople in 381. Imperial policy mattered profoundly: bishops did not debate in a political vacuum. Yet it would be simplistic to treat doctrine as merely imposed by power. The empire could exile bishops and privilege factions; it could not by decree make a formula the enduring grammar of Christian worship across rival cultures. The eventual settlement owed its durability to a convergence of exegesis, liturgy, theological argument, episcopal networks, and imperial enforcement.

11. Constantinople (381) and the Creed Recited Today

The creed commonly called "the Nicene Creed" in churches today is not the exact text of 325. It is the Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed, associated with the Council of Constantinople in 381. It retains the Nicene center while expanding the articles on incarnation, the Holy Spirit, the church, baptism, resurrection, and the age to come.

The Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed (381)

We believe in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of heaven and earth, and of all things visible and invisible.
 And in one Lord Jesus Christ, the only-begotten Son of God, begotten from the Father before all ages;
 Light from Light, true God from true God;
 begotten, not made, of one essence with the Father;
 through whom all things were made;
 who for us humans and for our salvation came down from heaven,
 and was incarnate from the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary, and became human;
 who was crucified for us under Pontius Pilate, suffered, and was buried;
 and rose on the third day according to the Scriptures;
 and ascended into heaven and is seated at the right hand of the Father;
 and will come again with glory to judge the living and the dead;

of whose kingdom there will be no end.
 And in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and giver of life,
 who proceeds from the Father,
 who with the Father and the Son is together worshiped and together glorified,
 who spoke through the prophets.
 In one holy catholic and apostolic Church.
 We confess one baptism for the forgiveness of sins.
 We look for the resurrection of the dead
 and the life of the age to come. Amen.

English rendering of the Greek text received at Chalcedon. The original says that the Spirit proceeds "from the Father"; the Western phrase "and the Son" is discussed in Chapter 15. ¹⁹

How it differs from 325

The 381 creed omits the 325 phrase "that is, from the essence of the Father" and the concluding anathemas. It adds "before all ages," a fuller incarnation clause, the historical name Pontius Pilate, burial, scriptural resurrection, enthronement, the endless kingdom, and an extensive confession of the Spirit. It also adds the church, baptism, resurrection of the dead, and the coming age. The result is more liturgical and narrative, even while remaining Nicene.

The Spirit: careful but unmistakable

The creed calls the Spirit "Lord" and "giver of life," places the Spirit within the one act of worship and glory offered with Father and Son, and identifies the Spirit as the voice of the prophets. It does not directly say "true God from true God" or "of one essence" of the Spirit. Some scholars see this as diplomatic restraint; others emphasize that shared worship and divine life-giving activity communicate the same theological conclusion. The council's first canon condemned several non-Nicene groups, including the Pneumatomachians.

A genuine historical puzzle: did the council compose this creed?

The acts of Constantinople I have not survived. The creed is not quoted in surviving records of the council of 382 or at Ephesus in 431. Its first explicit conciliar appearance is at Chalcedon in 451, where it was read as the faith of the 150 fathers assembled in Constantinople. Some bishops at Chalcedon initially seem not to have known the text. Since the nineteenth century, scholars have debated whether the council itself composed it, adopted an existing baptismal creed revised in a Nicene direction, or whether the association became fixed only later. ²⁰

The creed resembles formulas connected with Jerusalem and with Epiphanius of Salamis. It is not simply the 325 text with extra sentences; it appears to draw on a parallel baptismal tradition while incorporating Nicene phrases. The traditional association with 381 remains strong and was certainly established by 451, but historians should not pretend the documentary path is completely transparent.

From plural "we believe" to singular "I believe"

The conciliar Greek begins "We believe," the voice of assembled bishops and churches. Liturgical traditions often use the singular "I believe," especially in the West. The change is not merely grammatical. The creed is both the church's corporate confession and the worshiper's personal act. In baptism and Eucharist, the individual enters the "we"; in council, the "we" becomes a public norm for individual teaching.

12. Ephesus (431): No Rival Creed

The Council of Ephesus did not produce a new recited creed. Instead, it reaffirmed Nicaea and declared it unlawful to compose or present a different faith as a rival to that established by the fathers at Nicaea. ²¹ This prohibition later

complicated the status of both the creed associated with Constantinople and the Definition of Chalcedon. Councils would insist that they were not replacing Nicaea but explaining it against new errors.

Nestorius, Cyril, and the title Theotokos

The immediate controversy concerned Nestorius, bishop of Constantinople, and Cyril of Alexandria. Popular devotion called Mary *Theotokos*, "God-bearer" or "Mother of God." Nestorius worried that this language confused Christ's divinity and humanity or attributed birth and suffering directly to the divine nature. He preferred *Christotokos*, "Christ-bearer," in some contexts.

Cyril defended *Theotokos* not primarily as a statement about Mary in isolation but as a claim about the identity of the one born from her. The subject of the Gospel story is the eternal Word personally united to a complete humanity. Mary did not generate the divine nature, but the person she bore is truly God the Word incarnate. The council condemned Nestorius, though its proceedings were bitter, procedurally contested, and entangled with rivalry among major sees.

The Formula of Reunion (433)

Two years later, Cyril and eastern bishops reached a Formula of Reunion. It confessed Christ as perfect God and perfect man, of one essence with the Father according to divinity and of one essence with us according to humanity, and acknowledged the Virgin as Theotokos because the Word became flesh. This language prepared the way for Chalcedon, even as different parties continued to interpret "union" and "nature" differently.

Ephesus made a permanent procedural claim: later definitions must present themselves not as new gospels, but as faithful explanations of the Nicene faith.

13. Chalcedon (451): One Christ in Two Natures

If Nicaea asked whether the Son belongs fully to the divine identity, Chalcedon asked how the divine Son is related to the humanity he assumed. The controversy intensified after the monk Eutyches, opposing Nestorian division, spoke in a way that seemed to leave only one nature after the incarnation. A council at Ephesus in 449 rehabilitated Eutyches and deposed opponents amid intimidation; its enemies labeled it the "Robber Council." Emperor Marcian and Empress Pulcheria convened a new council at Chalcedon in 451.

Chalcedon received the creeds of Nicaea and Constantinople, Cyril's letters, and the Tome of Leo, bishop of Rome. The council did not aim to explain the mechanics of incarnation. Its Definition set paired boundaries: full divinity and full humanity, unity of person and distinction of natures.

The Definition of Chalcedon (451)

Following, then, the holy fathers, we all with one voice teach the confession of one and the same Son, our Lord Jesus Christ:

perfect in divinity and perfect in humanity,

the same truly God and truly human, of a rational soul and body,

of one essence with the Father according to the divinity, and the same of one essence with us according to the humanity,

like us in all things apart from sin;

begotten before the ages from the Father according to the divinity, and in the last days, for us and for our salvation, the same born from the Virgin Mary, the God-bearer, according to the humanity;

one and the same Christ, Son, Lord, only-begotten,

acknowledged in two natures,

without confusion, without change, without division, without separation;

the difference of the natures being in no way abolished because of the union, but rather the distinctive character of each nature being preserved and coming together into one person and one hypostasis;
 not parted or divided into two persons, but one and the same Son and only-begotten God, Word, Lord Jesus Christ;
 as the prophets from the beginning declared concerning him, and the Lord Jesus Christ himself taught us, and the creed of the fathers has handed down to us.

English rendering based on the Greek Definition of Chalcedon. The council's full decree surrounds this central paragraph with affirmations of Nicaea, Constantinople, Cyril, and Leo. ²²

The four adverbs

The most memorable words are negative: **without confusion, without change, without division, without separation**. The first pair resists any fusion or transformation that would destroy Christ's humanity or turn incarnation into a mixture. The second pair resists a partition of the one Christ into two acting subjects. The Definition says less about *how* union occurs than about what faithful speech must not do.

"In two natures" and the schism

Many Egyptian, Syrian, Armenian, and other Christians rejected Chalcedon, not because they denied Christ's humanity or divinity, but because they feared the phrase "in two natures" betrayed Cyril's emphasis on the one incarnate nature of the Word and opened the door to Nestorian division. These churches are now called Oriental Orthodox. They prefer *miaphysite* language - one united incarnate nature from divinity and humanity - rather than the polemical label *monophysite*, which can imply that humanity was swallowed up.

Modern dialogues have found that Chalcedonian and Oriental Orthodox traditions often share more Christological substance than the historical condemnations suggested. Differences of terminology, political identity, ecclesial memory, and authority remain, but mutually agreed statements frequently confess one and the same Christ, fully divine and fully human, without confusion and without division.

Why Chalcedon was both powerful and incomplete

Chalcedon gave later theology a durable grammar: one person, two natures. But it did not settle every question. How does the one Christ act? Does he have one will or two? How should divine and human activities be related? These questions produced the monothelite controversy and the Definition of Constantinople III in 680-681. A creed can close one door while revealing another corridor.

14. The Athanasian Creed

The Athanasian Creed, known by its opening Latin words *Quicumque vult* ("Whoever wishes"), is not by Athanasius. It was composed in Latin, reflects Augustinian and post-Chalcedonian theology, and likely arose in southern Gaul in the late fifth or early sixth century. Its attribution to Athanasius expressed doctrinal kinship with the great defender of Nicaea, not actual authorship. J. N. D. Kelly associates it with the theological milieu of Lérins and southern Gaul.

²³

Unlike the Apostles' and Nicene Creeds, it was not produced by an ecumenical council. It became highly authoritative in the medieval and Reformation West, entered the Western office, and was received in Anglican, Lutheran, and Reformed confessional traditions. It was never a standard Eastern creed.

The Athanasian Creed (Quicumque Vult)

Whoever wishes to be saved, before all things it is necessary that he hold the catholic faith.
 Unless a person keeps this faith whole and undefiled, without doubt he will perish eternally.
 And the catholic faith is this: that we worship one God in Trinity, and Trinity in unity;
 neither confusing the persons nor dividing the essence.

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For there is one person of the Father, another of the Son, and another of the Holy Spirit.
But the divinity of the Father, of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit is one; the glory equal, the majesty coeternal.
Such as the Father is, such is the Son, and such is the Holy Spirit.
The Father uncreated, the Son uncreated, and the Holy Spirit uncreated.
The Father infinite, the Son infinite, and the Holy Spirit infinite.
The Father eternal, the Son eternal, and the Holy Spirit eternal.
And yet they are not three eternal, but one eternal;
just as they are not three uncreated or three infinite beings, but one uncreated and one infinite.
Likewise the Father is almighty, the Son almighty, and the Holy Spirit almighty;
and yet they are not three almighties, but one almighty.
So the Father is God, the Son is God, and the Holy Spirit is God;
and yet they are not three Gods, but one God.
So the Father is Lord, the Son is Lord, and the Holy Spirit is Lord;
and yet they are not three Lords, but one Lord.
For just as Christian truth compels us to acknowledge each person by himself to be God and Lord,
so the catholic religion forbids us to say that there are three Gods or three Lords.
The Father is made of none, neither created nor begotten.
The Son is of the Father alone, neither made nor created, but begotten.
The Holy Spirit is of the Father and of the Son, neither made nor created nor begotten, but proceeding.
Therefore there is one Father, not three Fathers; one Son, not three Sons; one Holy Spirit, not three Holy Spirits.
And in this Trinity none is before or after another; none is greater or less than another.
But the whole three persons are coeternal with one another and coequal.
So that in all things, as has been said, the Trinity in unity and the unity in Trinity is to be worshiped.
Whoever wishes to be saved must think thus of the Trinity.
Furthermore, it is necessary for eternal salvation that one also faithfully believe the incarnation of our Lord Jesus Christ.
The right faith, then, is that we believe and confess that our Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, is God and human.
He is God, begotten from the essence of the Father before the ages; and human, born from the essence of his mother in the age;
perfect God and perfect human, composed of a rational soul and human flesh;
equal to the Father according to his divinity, less than the Father according to his humanity.
Although he is God and human, yet he is not two, but one Christ.
One, however, not by conversion of the divinity into flesh, but by assumption of the humanity into God;
one altogether, not by confusion of essence, but by unity of person.
For as the rational soul and flesh are one human being, so God and humanity are one Christ;
who suffered for our salvation, descended to the dead, rose again on the third day from the dead,
ascended into heaven, sits at the right hand of the Father, God Almighty,
from where he will come to judge the living and the dead.
At his coming all people will rise again with their bodies and give an account of their own deeds.
Those who have done good will enter eternal life, and those who have done evil will enter eternal fire.
This is the catholic faith. Unless a person believes it faithfully and firmly, he cannot be saved.

Modernized English based on the received Latin text and public-domain translations. The creed's salvation clauses have been interpreted in different ways; see discussion below.

Its Trinitarian logic

The first half alternates between distributive and unitive speech. Each person is uncreated, infinite, eternal, almighty, God, and Lord; yet there are not three uncreated beings, three eternals, or three Gods. The creed disciplines language in both directions: do not confuse the persons, and do not divide the essence.

Its language that the Spirit is "of the Father and of the Son" reflects Western theology and anticipates the filioque controversy. The formula does not quote the Nicene Creed's procession clause; it systematizes the Western Augustinian understanding of the Spirit's relation to Father and Son.

Its Christological logic

The second half condenses Chalcedonian theology. Christ is perfect God and perfect human, one not by turning divinity into flesh but by taking humanity into union. The analogy of soul and body forming one human being comes from earlier Latin theology, especially Augustine. Like all analogies, it illuminates one point - unity without loss of components - while risking misunderstanding if pressed too far.

The damnatory clauses

The opening and closing warnings are the creed's most controversial feature. In their historical setting they express the conviction that the identity of the God worshiped and the Christ trusted for salvation is not spiritually indifferent. Yet they have sometimes been read as declaring that every person unable to articulate technical Trinitarian grammar is condemned. Many churches that retain the creed interpret it ecclesially and doctrinally rather than as a psychological test imposed on every uninstructed individual. Others omit it from worship precisely because the clauses seem pastorally harsh.

15. The Filioque and the Creed as a Fault Line

The Greek creed of 381 says that the Holy Spirit "proceeds from the Father." In the Latin West, the phrase *filioque* - "and the Son" - was gradually added: the Spirit proceeds from the Father *and the Son*. The addition became one of the most famous disputes between Eastern and Western Christianity.

Why the West added it

The clause appeared in anti-Arian contexts in Spain, notably at the Third Council of Toledo in 589, and spread through Frankish territories. Western theologians, drawing on Augustine, emphasized the Spirit as the communion or mutual gift of Father and Son and interpreted scriptural statements about the Spirit of the Son and the Son sending the Spirit as support for procession from both. The addition also guarded the full equality of the Son against lingering subordinationism.

Why the East objected

Eastern objections were both theological and canonical. Theologically, many insisted that the Father alone is the personal source or cause within the Trinity; to say "from the Father and the Son" could seem to give the Godhead two sources or blur the Father's monarchy. Canonically, no regional church had authority to alter an ecumenical creed unilaterally. Rome itself resisted inserting the words into the creed for centuries even while affirming compatible theology, but the Latin liturgical text eventually received them.

Can the formulas be reconciled?

Modern ecumenical discussions distinguish the Greek verb *ekporeuesthai*, often reserved for origin from the Father as first source, from the broader Latin *procedere*. Some Western explanations say the Spirit proceeds from the Father

through the Son or from the Father and the Son as one principle, not from two independent causes. Many theologians believe these clarifications reduce the doctrinal distance, though the question of altering the creed remains.

The filioque controversy shows that a creed can be both a bond of unity and a record of broken communion. The exact words matter because they are shared words.

16. Later Ecumenical Councils and Why They Did Not Replace Nicaea

The early church continued to issue doctrinal definitions after Chalcedon, but no later text displaced the Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed as the principal liturgical confession of the catholic tradition. Later councils presented their work as interpretation of Nicaea and Chalcedon rather than a new foundational creed.

Constantinople II (553)

The fifth ecumenical council sought to secure a Cyrillian reading of Chalcedon and condemned the "Three Chapters" associated with Theodore of Mopsuestia, Theodoret of Cyrus, and Ibas of Edessa. Its decisions deepened conflict in the West and did not reconcile the non-Chalcedonian churches. The council shows how reception of a creed depends on interpretation: Chalcedon could be read in a more Antiochene or more Cyrillian direction.

Constantinople III (680-681)

The monothelite controversy asked whether Christ, because he is one person, has one will, or whether complete humanity requires a human will distinct from the divine will. The council taught two natural wills and two natural operations, divine and human, without division or opposition, the human will freely following the divine. This extended Chalcedon's two-natures grammar into the sphere of action and willing.²⁴

Nicaea II (787)

The icon controversy concerned whether images of Christ and the saints could be venerated. Iconoclasts feared idolatry; defenders argued that because the Word truly became visible flesh, Christ can be depicted. The council distinguished *latreia*, worship owed to God alone, from the relative veneration shown to images, whose honor passes to the prototype. The decision was not a new creed but an application of incarnation theology to material devotion.²⁵

Why no endless sequence of new universal creeds?

A creed works partly because it is memorable and stable. Every controversy cannot be inserted into the weekly liturgy without turning confession into a library catalog. The Nicene Creed remained central because it names the triune God, the saving narrative of Christ, the Spirit, church, baptism, resurrection, and the coming age. Later definitions became interpretive guardrails around this core rather than replacements for it.

17. What the Creeds Accomplished - and What They Could Not

The creeds gave Christianity a shared public grammar. They protected continuity between the God of creation and the God of salvation, between the eternal Son and Jesus of Nazareth, between divine transcendence and genuine

incarnation, and between spiritual salvation and bodily resurrection. They formed generations of believers who could not read, placing a theological map in memory and worship.

They made claims testable

A creed exposes a church to its own standards. A community that says the Son became human cannot treat embodied life as worthless. A church that confesses one baptism and one catholic church must confront its divisions. A people who await the resurrection of the dead cannot reduce salvation to private inward escape. The creed can become rote, but it can also function as a measuring rod against the church's failures.

They did not eliminate interpretation

Every creedal phrase requires exegesis. What does "one essence" mean? What is a "person"? How does the Spirit proceed? What does "descended to the dead" signify? Why is the church called one when Christians are divided? The creed stabilizes questions; it does not abolish them. Its language is a disciplined beginning for theology, not the end of thought.

They did not emerge without power and conflict

Councils were not disembodied seminars. Emperors convened them, officials managed them, bishops competed for influence, mobs sometimes threatened violence, and defeated parties experienced exile or suppression. Historical honesty requires that doctrinal achievement not be used to excuse coercion. It also requires that political entanglement not be used as a shortcut for dismissing every theological argument. Ideas can be true or false even when argued by compromised people within compromised institutions.

They are not substitutes for Scripture

The ancient creeds present themselves as summaries and interpretations of the biblical witness. They repeatedly say "according to the Scriptures" and trace their authority to apostolic teaching. Churches differ over the precise relation of creed, Scripture, tradition, and teaching office. Yet the classic creeds are deliberately sparse on issues where later Christians divided: justification, predestination, sacraments, papal authority, biblical canon, church government, and many ethical questions. Their silence is part of their ecumenical power.

Their enduring invitation

From 1 Corinthians 15 to Chalcedon, the creedal story moves from proclamation to interpretation. "Christ died ... was buried ... was raised ... appeared" becomes "true God from true God," "became human," "one and the same Christ," and "without confusion, without division." The later language does not replace the primitive gospel; it asks what must be true of God and Christ if that gospel is to be spoken coherently.

The earliest creed says what happened. Nicaea asks who the risen Christ must be. Chalcedon asks how that divine Son can truly live, suffer, die, and rise as human. The history of creeds is the history of the church learning to keep all three questions together.

Appendix A. Chronological Reader of Major Texts

This appendix gathers the principal texts in one place for uninterrupted reading. Historical introductions and textual cautions appear in the chapters above.

1. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8

For I delivered to you first of all that which I also received: that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures; that he was buried; that he was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures; and that he appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve. Then he appeared to over five hundred brothers at once, most of whom remain until now, but some have also fallen asleep. Then he appeared to James, then to all the apostles; and last of all, as to the child born at the wrong time, he appeared to me also.

2. Irenaeus - Rule of Truth

The Church, though dispersed throughout the whole world, has received from the apostles and their disciples faith in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of heaven and earth and all things; in one Christ Jesus, the Son of God, incarnate for our salvation; and in the Holy Spirit, who through the prophets proclaimed the saving economy, the advents, the birth from a virgin, the passion, resurrection, ascension, and glorious return of Christ Jesus our Lord.

3. Tertullian - Rule of Faith

There is one God, the Creator; his Word is his Son; the Son was promised through prophets, born from the Virgin by the Spirit, preached the kingdom, was crucified, rose on the third day, ascended, sits at the Father's right hand, sent the Holy Spirit, and will return in glory to raise and judge humanity.

4. Interrogatory Baptismal Creed

Do you believe in God the Father Almighty? I believe.

Do you believe in Christ Jesus, the Son of God, born through the Holy Spirit from the Virgin Mary, crucified under Pontius Pilate, dead and buried, risen on the third day, ascended, seated at the Father's right hand, and coming to judge the living and the dead? I believe.

Do you believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy Church, and the resurrection of the flesh? I believe.

5. Old Roman Symbol

I believe in God the Father Almighty; and in Christ Jesus, his only Son, our Lord, born of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary, crucified and buried under Pontius Pilate, risen on the third day, ascended into heaven, seated at the Father's right hand, coming to judge the living and the dead; and in the Holy Spirit, the holy Church, forgiveness of sins, resurrection of the flesh, and life everlasting.

6. Apostles' Creed

I believe in God, the Father Almighty, creator of heaven and earth; and in Jesus Christ, his only Son, our Lord, conceived by the Holy Spirit, born of the Virgin Mary, suffered under Pontius Pilate, crucified, died, and buried; descended to the dead; rose on the third day; ascended into heaven; is seated at the right hand of the Father; and will come to judge the living and the dead. I believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy catholic Church, communion of saints, forgiveness of sins, resurrection of the body, and life everlasting. Amen.

7. Nicaea (325)

We believe in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of all things visible and invisible; and in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, begotten from the Father, from the Father's essence, God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God, begotten not made, of one essence with the Father, through whom all things came to be; who for us and for our salvation came down, was incarnate, became human, suffered, rose on the third day, ascended, and is coming to judge the living and the dead; and in the Holy Spirit.

8. Constantinople (381)

We believe in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of heaven and earth, and all things visible and invisible; and in one Lord Jesus Christ, the only-begotten Son of God, begotten from the Father before all ages, Light from Light, true God from

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true God, begotten not made, of one essence with the Father, through whom all things were made; who for us and for our salvation came down, was incarnate by the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary, became human, was crucified for us under Pontius Pilate, suffered, was buried, rose on the third day according to the Scriptures, ascended, is seated at the Father's right hand, and will come in glory to judge the living and the dead, whose kingdom will have no end; and in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and giver of life, who proceeds from the Father, who with Father and Son is worshiped and glorified, who spoke through the prophets; in one holy catholic and apostolic Church; one baptism for forgiveness; resurrection of the dead; and the life of the coming age. Amen.

9. Chalcedon (451)

We confess one and the same Son, our Lord Jesus Christ, perfect in divinity and perfect in humanity, truly God and truly human, of a rational soul and body, of one essence with the Father according to divinity and of one essence with us according to humanity, like us in all things except sin; one and the same Christ acknowledged in two natures, without confusion, without change, without division, without separation; the distinction of natures preserved in one person and one hypostasis.

10. Athanasian Creed - Core Summary

We worship one God in Trinity and Trinity in unity, neither confusing the persons nor dividing the essence. The Father is God, the Son is God, and the Holy Spirit is God, yet there are not three Gods but one God. Our Lord Jesus Christ is perfect God and perfect human, one Christ, not by confusion of essence but by unity of person.

The complete text appears in Chapter 14.

Appendix B. Comparative Tables

From proclamation to doctrinal precision

Text	Central Question	Characteristic Language	Primary Use
1 Corinthians 15	What saving event is proclaimed?	Died, buried, raised, appeared	Preaching and argument
Rule of Faith	What story governs Scripture?	Creator, incarnation, resurrection, judgment	Catechesis and anti-heresy
Old Roman / Apostles	What faith is confessed in baptism?	I believe; Father, Son, Spirit	Baptism and instruction
Nicaea 325	Is the Son truly divine or created?	Begotten not made; homoousios	Conciliar boundary
Constantinople 381	How is the Spirit confessed?	Lord, giver of life, worshiped and glorified	Ecumenical and liturgical creed
Chalcedon 451	How is Christ divine and human?	One person, two natures; four adverbs	Christological definition
Athanasian Creed	How are unity and Trinity coordinated?	One essence; three persons; coequal	Western doctrinal instruction

Major additions from the Old Roman Symbol to the Apostles' Creed

Later Clause	Likely Function	Historical Note
Creator of heaven and earth	Makes creation confession explicit	Strengthens anti-Gnostic continuity
Conceived by the Holy Spirit	Separates conception and birth clauses	Developed from earlier birth formula
Suffered	Emphasizes real passion	Anti-docetic force
Descended to the dead	Extends burial/descent motif	Regional and late addition
Catholic	Names universal church	Not a denominational label in origin
Communion of saints	Communion of holy persons/things	Meaning historically multivalent
Life everlasting	Completes eschatological hope	Present in some Old Roman witnesses

The four great creedal guardrails

Creator and creation: The Father of Jesus Christ is the maker of the material world; salvation fulfills rather than abandons creation.

True divinity of the Son: The Son is begotten, not made, and shares the divine essence; Christian worship is not directed to a creature.

True humanity of Christ: The Word assumes complete humanity, including rational soul, body, human will, suffering, and death.

Unity without confusion: The one Christ is neither a fused hybrid nor two personal subjects; distinction and unity must both be confessed.

Notes

1. World English Bible, 1 Corinthians 15:3-8. The WEB is public domain.
2. Anthony C. Thiselton, *The First Epistle to the Corinthians: A Commentary on the Greek Text* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2000), discussion of 1 Corinthians 15:1-11; Gordon D. Fee, *The First Epistle to the Corinthians*, rev. ed. (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2014), on 15:3-7.
3. James D. G. Dunn, *Jesus Remembered* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2003), 854-55.
4. Gerd Luedemann, *The Resurrection of Jesus: History, Experience, Theology*, trans. John Bowden (Minneapolis: Fortress, 1994), 171-72.
5. Bart D. Ehrman, *How Jesus Became God* (New York: HarperOne, 2014), treatment of early pre-Pauline traditions; see also Ehrman, "The Earliest Understanding of Christ? The Hint in Paul's Writings," for the caution that "pre-Pauline" does not by itself establish a pre-conversion date.
6. Dale C. Allison Jr., *Resurrecting Jesus: The Earliest Christian Tradition and Its Interpreters* (New York: T&T Clark, 2005), 234; Joseph A. Fitzmyer, *First Corinthians* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2008), on 15:3-8.
7. Larry W. Hurtado, *Lord Jesus Christ: Devotion to Jesus in Earliest Christianity* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2003); Richard Bauckham, *Jesus and the God of Israel* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2008), especially on 1 Corinthians 8:6.
8. J. N. D. Kelly, *Early Christian Creeds*, 3rd ed. (London: Longman, 1972), opening definition and chapters 1-2; Wolfram Kinzig, *A History of Early Christian Creeds* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2024), introduction.
9. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 1.10.1, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson; Irenaeus, *Demonstration of the Apostolic Preaching* 6-7.
10. Tertullian, *Prescription Against Heretics* 13 and *Against Praxeas* 2, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 3.
11. Justin Martyr, *First Apology* 61, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1.
12. *Apostolic Tradition* 21, trans. Burton Scott Easton; for the composite-text debate, see Paul F. Bradshaw, Maxwell E. Johnson, and L. Edward Phillips, *The Apostolic Tradition: A Commentary* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2002).
13. Kelly, *Early Christian Creeds*, 102-103; Marcellus of Ancyra's creed preserved in Epiphanius, *Panarion* 72; Rufinus, *Commentary on the Apostles' Creed*.
14. Kelly, *Early Christian Creeds*, chapters 4-6; Philip Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 1, section on the Apostles' Creed.
15. Lewis Ayres, *Nicaea and Its Legacy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004); R. P. C. Hanson, *The Search for the Christian Doctrine of God* (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1988); Eusebius, *Life of Constantine* 3.6-14.
16. Creed of Nicaea in Athanasius, *De Decretis*; Eusebius, Letter to the Church of Caesarea; Philip Schaff and Henry Wace, eds., *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, second series, vol. 14.
17. Eusebius of Caesarea, Letter to the Church of Caesarea, preserved in Athanasius, *De Decretis* and Theodoret, *Ecclesiastical History* 1.12.
18. Hanson, *Search for the Christian Doctrine of God*; Ayres, *Nicaea and Its Legacy*; John Behr, *The Nicene Faith*, 2 vols. (Crestwood, NY: St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2004).
19. Creed associated with Constantinople I, preserved in the acts of Chalcedon; Schaff and Wace, *NPNF*, second series, vol. 14.
20. Kelly, *Early Christian Creeds*, treatment of the Constantinopolitan Creed; Kinzig, *History of Early Christian Creeds*; Richard Price and Michael Gaddis, trans., *The Acts of the Council of Chalcedon*, 3 vols. (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2005).
21. Council of Ephesus, session 6 and Canon 7, in Norman P. Tanner, ed., *Decrees of the Ecumenical Councils*, vol. 1 (Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press, 1990); public-domain translation in *NPNF*, second series, vol. 14.
22. Definition of Chalcedon, in Price and Gaddis, *Acts of Chalcedon*; Frances M. Young with Andrew Teal, *From Nicaea to Chalcedon*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2010).
23. J. N. D. Kelly, *The Athanasian Creed* (London: Adam & Charles Black, 1964); Schaff, *Creeds of Christendom*, vol. 2.
24. Definition of Constantinople III, in Tanner, *Decrees*, vol. 1; Maximus the Confessor is the major theological background.
25. Definition of Nicaea II, in Tanner, *Decrees*, vol. 1; public-domain translation in *NPNF*, second series, vol. 14.

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